

Andy Cohen still a baseball fixture

There is a special fascination about baseball, an aura to which this oldtimer holds exclusive rights. It's a certain immutability. Baseball never changes, not really. What was good strategy in 1901 will generally be good strategy in 1981, or 2001 for that matter, even if a computer is flashing signals from the third base coaching box.

It is the only sport which spans this tumultuous 20th century. Major league baseball, in particular, has been a perpetual calendar, graciously ticking off the years, marking time.

Almost every present-day manager in baseball can be traced back to two men who were teaching the game in weaning of this century — John McGraw and Branch Rickey. McGraw managed the Giants for more than 30 years and Rickey built two organizations, the Cardinals and the Dodgers. McGraw begat Casey Stengel, who tutored Billy Martin. Gene Mauch, Dick Williams, Tom Lasorda and Danny Ozark are products of Rickey's Dodger system. Jim Fregosi played under Bill Rigney, who played under Mel Ott, who played under, yep, John J. McGraw.

Leonard Koppett, a renowned sports writer for the New York Times, once pointed out that the current increase of base-stealing in the majors was coming from teams whose managers were disciples of either McGraw or Rickey.

But Koppett had to search to find a link with those men to Chuck Tanner, whose teams at Oakland and Pittsburgh were, and are, baseball's best thieves on the basepaths. But he concluded: "Do you know who Chuck Tanner's closest friend is, who managed him in the minors and who was, says Tanner, 'like a father to me?' Andy Cohen . . ."

Fifty years ago this summer, Andy Cohen played his last season of major league baseball. That was 1929, folks. He was the second baseman on the



Vince Langford

Times Sports Writer

New York Giants, managed by McGraw, "Little Napoleon."

This past week, Andy Cohen, who will celebrate the 75th year of his being in October just after the 78th World Series concludes, returned to the diamond as first base coach for the El Paso Diablos. He had been a coach with the El Paso teams when Tanner was a manager here.

His brother Syd, now serving as the Diablos' bullpen coach, also had more than a mild acquaintance with the immortals of the game. Syd Cohen pitched for parts of three seasons with the Washington Senators and as a 26-year-old rookie in 1934, he not only gave up Babe Ruth's last American League home run, but also, in the aging Bambino's last at-bat as an American Leaguer, Syd struck him out. The next year, Ruth closed out his career with the Boston Braves.

Andy Cohen admits that his eyesight isn't what it once was. He was asked by Jim Paul, the president and general manager of the Diablos, to coach first base and when told that Manager Moose Stubing was behind it all the way, he accepted. "I'll just see how long I can go," he says.

He also admits that he missed being in the game this spring. He retired as coach of the UTEP baseball team after 17 seasons at the end of last year.

Before he was called out of retirement, he was out to every Diablo game, sitting with his brother in a box seat near the Diablo dugout, observing baseball as he has during a career as player, manager and college coach that would cover 55 years if not for the

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